



Chapter 8

User personas

Parenthood and the Parent Layer · the loop closes

You're the grown-up now, the one Chapter 1 was about, seen from the other side. The job flips from learning to being the safe source the next child will need. This is where the eight-chapter loop closes, and where the whole product was always headed: raising the next generation better than we were raised.

Now you're the grown-up in the room.

Eight chapters ago, this player was a three-year-old being co-played by a nervous parent. Now they are that parent. The job inverts: from being taught, to being the trusted, safe source a small person needs, the exact role the whole DD499 research said matters most. And it all arrives at once, on no sleep: a strained marriage, an erased self, an unhealed childhood resurfacing, and a tiny human copying everything you do. Chapter 8 is the Parent Layer, and it is where the loop closes.

The loop, closed

A Chapter 8 graduate is a Chapter 1 operator. The parent who learns to break the cycle, look after themselves, and have the talks becomes the safe adult who guides their own child into Chapter 1, with what they never got. Unlearn, relearn, grow, for one more generation.

Four shifts from Chapter 7

SHIFT	WHAT IT MEANS	WHAT THE DESIGN MUST DO
Learner becomes teacher	The player is now the safe source for the next child.	Equip the Parent Layer: the talks, age by age, done right.
The past resurfaces	Their own childhood, good and bad, drives how they parent under stress.	Help break the cycle with compassion, not blame.
Zero time, high fear	Exhausted, terrified of getting it wrong, ruled by a "good parent" myth.	Bite-sized, non-judgmental help, available at 2am.
Difference shows up	Gender-diverse and neurodiverse children need affirming, informed parents.	Acceptance as protection; practical, stigma-free support.

Eight personas: six parents across Indian segments, two reach channels. Each ends in design implications for the nine Chapter 8 games: Us After Kids, Equal Parents, Looking After You, The Talks, Break the Cycle, Raising Gender-Diverse Kids, Raising Neurodiverse Kids, Navigating Addictions, and Be the Safe Adult.

The grown-ups Chapter 1 was waiting for.

These parents are, quite literally, the operators from Chapter 1, met at the moment they become them. Plus the two professionals who reach new parents when it's hardest.

PERSONA	ROLE	SEGMENT	IN ONE LINE	THE LEVER FOR DEPTH
Divya, 30	Parent	Urban, new mother	A baby, no sleep, and no one asks how she is.	Look after the parent.
Vikram, 34	Parent	Urban father	Loves his kids; "babysits" his own kids.	From helping to owning.
Suresh, 35	Parent	Tier-2	Swore he'd never hit; some days he nearly does.	Break the cycle, with compassion.
Meena, 36	Parent	Urban	Her son's "misbehaviour" is autism, undiagnosed too long.	Affirm and support difference.
Priya, 34	Parent	Urban	Her little boy loves dresses; the relatives panic.	Affirming is protective.
Kamla, 33	Parent	Low-income	Shielding the kids from a drinking husband, alone.	Safety, addiction, the safe adult.
Dr. Nair, 48	Channel	Pediatrician	The expert exhausted parents actually trust.	Trusted referral at the touchpoint.
Sushila, 40	Channel	ASHA / community	The only support some new mothers get.	Equity reach; offline, in-language.

Divya, 30

Marketing manager on leave · urban · six-month-old · the disappearing self

"Everyone asks about the baby. Nobody asks about me. I don't cry in front of them, I cry in the bathroom, and I tell myself this is just how it is."

LIVES	With husband and in-laws; first baby; on maternity leave.
LOAD	The default parent from day one; up every night; managing everyone's advice.
DEVICES	Phone in one hand while feeding; 2am searches about the baby and herself.
SUPPORT	Lots of opinions, little real help; her own identity on pause.
RISK	Likely postpartum anxiety or depression, unnamed and unscreened.

The fourth trimester. Divya loves her baby and has lost herself. She is exhausted, anxious, and quietly grieving the person she was, while a chorus tells her this is the happiest time of her life. Postpartum depression is common and badly under-recognised in India; she has no name for what she feels and no permission to feel it. She does not need parenting tips first. She needs someone to ask how she is.

What she wants

- To feel like a person, not only a mother.
- To know what she's feeling is real, common and treatable.
- Practical help sharing the load, not more pressure to do it all.
- Permission to rest, ask for help, and not be "the perfect mum".

The myth she carries

That a good mother dissolves herself into the child, and that struggling means she is failing at the one thing she's meant to be built for.

~~A good mother sacrifices everything.~~

~~Baby blues, just push through.~~

She needs her own wellbeing treated as part of the baby's, not a luxury.

Why she'd bounce

- Cheery "cherish every moment" content; it deepens the guilt.
- Baby-first apps that ignore the mother entirely.
- Anything that adds a task to a person who has no capacity left.

HURTS DIVYA

A glowing "enjoy this magical time" message. It tells her the problem is her.

MAGIC TO DIVYA

Something that asks how she is, names postpartum struggles as real and common, and helps her get rest and help.

Design implications

- 1 Put the parent's wellbeing first; "you can't pour from empty" is the design's spine.
- 2 Name and normalise postpartum depression and anxiety; route to real help.
- 3 Reduce load, never add it; tiny, restful, no homework.
- 4 Reject the perfect-mother myth explicitly; rest and help are not failure.

Vikram, 34

Sales lead · urban · two kids · the dad who "babysits"

"I'm a hands-on dad. I babysit them every Sunday so she gets a break. I genuinely don't see what more I'm supposed to do."

LIVES	Nuclear; both worked, she scaled back after kids.
ROLE	The provider; the "fun parent"; helps when asked.
DEVICES	Heavy user; would never open a "how to parent" article.
SUPPORT	Took no paternity leave; male friends model the same.
BLIND SPOT	Can't see the management: the appointments, the planning, the worry.

The male arc's last stage. Vikram is Veer, then Rohan, then the husband, now a father, and a loving one. But he still thinks parenting his own children is "babysitting", and that being present on Sundays makes him equal. He isn't a bad dad; he's a half-time one who thinks he's full-time. Shame won't move him. Showing him the invisible management he never notices, and what his kids learn from watching him, will.

What he wants

- To be a good father, and to be seen as one.
- To understand why his wife is overwhelmed when he "helps so much".
- Concrete things to do, not vague guilt.
- To raise kids who respect him, and her.

Why he'd bounce

- Being called a deadbeat or part of the problem.
- Preachy "step up, dad" tone with no respect for what he does.
- Anything that sounds like his wife's complaint, automated.

BACKFIRES FOR VIKRAM

A "do your share, dad" scolding. He files it as nagging and tunes out.

The myth he carries

That a father's job is to provide and play, that caregiving is "helping" hers, and that his kids won't notice the difference.

~~I'm babysitting my own kids.~~

~~Earning is my half of parenting.~~

His children are watching what a father does; that's the lever.

MAGIC TO VIKRAM

A sharp reveal of the invisible parenting load and of what his kids learn from him, with concrete ways to truly co-parent.

Design implications

- 1 Reach fathers directly; co-parenting is not a mothers-only topic.
- 2 Reframe "babysitting" and "helping" as full, owned parenting.
- 3 Use the modelling lever: kids learn equality, or its absence, from him.
- 4 Respect his effort; concrete actions over guilt; close the male arc warmly.

Suresh, 35

Shopkeeper · tier-2 · two kids · trying to break what raised him

"My father's belt taught me respect, or so they said. I swore I'd never. Then my son tests me at the end of a long day, and I hear my father's voice in my mouth."

LIVES	Joint family; raised with corporal punishment and silence.
GOAL	To parent differently; slips into old patterns under stress.
DEVICES	Phone for everything; learns from short videos, not articles.
SUPPORT	Elders who endorse the old ways; few models for the new.
CYCLE	Two cycles to break: the hitting, and the not-talking.

The voice in his mouth. Suresh genuinely wants to be a gentler father than his own, and most days he is. But when he's tired and his kid pushes, the only script he was given kicks in, the raised hand, the shouted shame, and the refusal to ever discuss "those" topics. He doesn't need to be told he's a bad father; he's the opposite, he's trying. He needs better tools than the ones he inherited, and forgiveness for the days he reaches for the old ones.

What he wants

- To raise his kids with love and limits, not fear.
- Practical discipline that works without hitting or shaming.
- To talk to his kids about the things no one talked to him about.
- To not feel like a failure on the days he slips.

The myth he carries

That fear makes good children, that he turned out fine, and that some topics are simply not for parents to discuss.

~~I was hit and I turned out fine.~~

~~Those topics are the school's job.~~

Break two cycles: the hitting and the silence; with compassion, not blame.

Why he'd bounce

- Being branded an abuser for one bad evening.
- Urban, jargon-heavy "gentle parenting" with no respect for his world.
- Lectures that condemn his own parents and culture wholesale.

LOSES SURESH

A judgmental "stop hitting your child" message. He shuts it, ashamed and defensive.

MAGIC TO SURESH

Real, doable tools for limits without fear, words to start the talks, and grace for the hard days.

Design implications

- 1 Break the cycle with compassion: never shame the trying parent.
- 2 Give practical positive-discipline tools, plus repair for the slips.
- 3 Break the silence cycle too: scripts to start the talks he never got.
- 4 Respect his world; short video-led, not urban jargon.

Meena, 36

Teacher · urban · son, 5, recently diagnosed autistic · the blamed parent

"For two years they said he was just naughty, and that I'd spoiled him. He's autistic. I lost two years to other people's opinions."

LIVES	Nuclear; one child; both parents working and stretched.
JOURNEY	Late diagnosis after years of blame; now learning to support him.
DEVICES	Researches constantly; sifts good info from a sea of bad.
SUPPORT	Stigma from family and school; few affordable services.
NEED	Acceptance and tools, not a "cure" or a culprit.

After the diagnosis. Meena spent years being told her son's meltdowns were bad behaviour and bad parenting, the classic "too much screen time" verdict. The diagnosis was a relief and a new mountain: stigma, scarce services, a school that doesn't accommodate, and a flood of online misinformation. She doesn't want him fixed; she wants him understood, supported and safe, and she needs reliable help to do it, plus someone to tell her it isn't her fault.

What she wants

- To understand and support her son as he is.
- Reliable information, free of stigma and miracle "cures".
- Help with school, family and the world's judgement.
- To hear, clearly, that it is not her fault.

Why she'd bounce

- Anything implying she caused it, or that it can be cured away.
- Generic parenting advice that ignores neurodivergence.
- Pity; she wants partnership and tools.

WRONG FOR MEENA

One-size parenting tips, or "cure autism" quackery. Useless or harmful.

The myth she's up against

That neurodivergence is bad behaviour or bad parenting, and that the goal is to make the child "normal".

~~He's just spoiled and badly behaved.~~
~~Too much screen time caused it.~~

Difference is to be understood and supported, not blamed or erased.

MAGIC TO MEENA

Stigma-free, reliable support for raising a neurodiverse child, with a clear "this is not your fault".

Design implications

- 1 Frame neurodivergence as difference to support, never a fault or a disease to cure.
- 2 Give reliable, clinically-grounded information; counter the misinformation flood.
- 3 Help with the real battles: school accommodation, family stigma, services.
- 4 Tell the parent plainly it is not their fault; offer partnership, not pity.

ADULT · THE PLAYER

Priya, 34

Banker · urban · son, 5, who loves dresses · the frightened, loving parent

"He's happiest in his sister's frock, twirling. I'm not upset, I'm scared, of what the relatives will say, of what the world will do to him."

LIVES	Nuclear, near extended family; a gender-nonconforming young child.
STANCE	Loving and afraid; unsure whether to affirm or "correct".
DEVICES	Searches quietly; fears both wrong answers and the relatives finding out.
SUPPORT	Pressure to "discipline it out"; little affirming guidance.
STAKES	How she responds now shapes his safety and self-worth for life.

The fork, early. Priya's child is simply being himself, and the family is already anxious. She is not a bigot; she is a frightened parent who has been handed a script that says "correct it" and no script that says "support him". This is the same crossroads Anjali faced in Chapter 5, but a decade earlier, when it matters even more. Affirming, accepting parenting is the single biggest protective factor for a gender-diverse child. She needs to know that, and how.

What she wants

- To do right by her child, whatever his path turns out to be.
- To replace fear with facts about gender-diverse kids.
- To handle relatives and school without exposing or shaming him.
- To keep him safe, confident and loved.

The myth she's handed

That a gender-nonconforming child is a problem to fix, and that affirming him will "make" him something or harm him.

It's a phase, discipline it out.

Letting him will confuse him.

Affirming is protective; she needs that fact and the how-to.

Why she'd bounce

- Content that treats her fear as hate; she's trying.
- Either extreme: "discipline it out" or "you must label him now".
- Advice blind to Indian-family and safety realities.

PUSHES PRIYA AWAY

Content that scolds her fear, or that pushes a label onto a five-year-old.

MAGIC TO PRIYA

Calm facts that affirming is protective, plus how to support him and handle the relatives without a war.

Design implications

- 1 Meet parental fear with patience and facts, never with "you're a bigot".
- 2 Centre the evidence: affirming, accepting parenting protects the child.
- 3 Avoid both extremes; support the child without forcing labels.
- 4 Address Indian-family and safety realities directly and practically.

Kamla, 33

Domestic worker · low-income · three kids · the only safe adult they have

"When he drinks, I keep the children in the other room. I am their mother and their shield. I just want them to have someone they can always tell the truth to."

LIVES	One room; husband drinks; she holds the family together.
ROLE	Sole protector and stable adult for three children.
DEVICES	One basic phone; little privacy; reads slowly.
SUPPORT	An ASHA worker; a neighbour; no formal help.
NEED	To keep the kids safe, and to be the open door she never had.

The shield. Kamla is parenting in survival mode: a partner's addiction, money stress, and the daily work of keeping three children safe and steady. She grew up where children were told nothing and trusted no adult. She wants to be different, the parent her kids can always come to, especially about safety. She needs practical help on her husband's drinking, on protecting the children, and on being the open, no-blame safe adult that closes the loop into the next generation.

What she wants

- Her children safe, steady and able to tell her anything.
- Practical help around a partner's drinking and its effect on the kids.
- To be the trusted adult she never had growing up.
- To know where real help exists, quietly and safely.

Why she'd bounce

- English, text-heavy, or anything needing privacy she lacks.
- Judgement of her, her husband or her choices.
- Advice that ignores how little time and money she has.

USELESS TO KAMLA

A polished parenting app in English assuming time, money and privacy she doesn't have.

The myth she's unlearning

That family troubles stay hidden, that "stranger danger" is the real risk, and that children are safest kept in the dark.

What happens at home stays at home.

Stranger danger is the real risk.

Most harm comes from known adults; the open, safe parent is the protection.

MAGIC TO KAMLA

An offline, spoken, gentle guide to keeping her kids safe, handling the drinking, and being the open door, with real help signposted.

Design implications

- 1 Offline, audio-first, in-language, safety-first for parents in survival mode.
- 2 Navigate addiction in the family: protect the kids, find support, no shame.
- 3 Teach safe-adult parenting: open door, no blame, known-adult risk, POCSO-aware.
- 4 Signpost real help (ASHA, helplines, de-addiction, Childline) discreetly.

PEDIATRICIAN

Dr. Nair, 48

Pediatrician · the expert exhausted parents actually listen to

"Half my consult is 'is my child normal?' and 'how do I handle this?'. I have seven minutes. I'd love something good to send them home with."

Reality

- The trusted touchpoint for new and young-child parents.
- Fields development, behaviour, postpartum and "the talks" questions in minutes.
- First to spot postpartum depression, developmental flags, unsafe homes.
- Wants reliable take-home support to extend a short consult.

WON'T RECOMMEND

Pop-psychology or anything not medically sound. His name is on it.

What he needs from SwipeEd. Accurate, calm parent content he can recommend by topic, postpartum mental health, positive discipline, neurodiversity, the talks, that he trusts enough to put his name behind. Something that carries on the guidance he has no time to give in full, screens gently for parents who need more help, and routes them to it.

MAGIC TO DR. NAIR

Clinically sound, recommend-by-topic parent support he can hand over in his seven minutes, with referral built in.

Design implications

- 1 Be clinically sound enough for a doctor to put his name behind.
- 2 Organise as recommend-by-topic take-home support, not a course.
- 3 Screen gently for postpartum and developmental concerns; route to help.
- 4 Deployable at the clinic touchpoint with zero admin.

Sushila, 40

ASHA and early-childhood worker · the only support some new mothers get

"I'm in their homes for the immunisations anyway. I see the mother no one is checking on, and the child no one is reading to."

Reality

- Visits low-income homes for maternal and child health.
- Often the only outsider who sees a struggling new mother.
- Trusted, local, multilingual; works with very low resources.
- Handles postpartum, early childhood, safeguarding, in passing.

UNUSABLE FOR HER

An online, English, middle-class parenting app. It fits none of her families.

What she needs from SwipeEd. Offline, spoken, local-language parent content she can play on a home visit or leave with a mother who can't read much: postpartum wellbeing, positive parenting, the safe-adult basics. A tool that extends her into the homes the formal system barely reaches, and turns a vaccination visit into a moment of real parenting support.

MAGIC TO SUSHILA

An offline, spoken, local-language kit she can share on a home visit, on postpartum wellbeing and safe-adult parenting.

Design implications

- 1 Offline, audio-first, local-language; deliverable on a home visit.
- 2 Prioritise postpartum wellbeing, positive parenting and safe-adult basics.
- 3 Reach the homes the formal system barely touches.
- 4 Route to ASHA, helplines and services; never just inform.

What Chapter 8 must do differently.

Across all eight personas, one demand dominates: help an exhausted, frightened, loving parent break the cycle and become the safe source, the one Chapter 1 was always waiting for. This is the Parent Layer, and the point of the whole product.

PRINCIPLE	BECAUSE	SHOWS UP AS
Look after the parent	You can't pour from empty; postpartum and burnout are real and ignored.	Parent wellbeing first; name PPD; reduce load, never add it.
Help at 2am, no judgment	Exhausted, terrified parents ruled by a "good parent" myth.	Bite-sized, non-shaming, just-in-time, recommend-by-topic.
Break the cycle gently	The past drives parenting under stress; shame entrenches it.	Compassion not blame; positive discipline; repair; break the silence too.
Make it an equal job	The default parent and the "babysitting" dad are the norm.	Reach fathers; helping becomes owning; kids learn from both.
Affirm difference	Gender-diverse and neurodiverse kids depend on informed parents.	Acceptance as protection; stigma-free, reliable, practical support.
Equip the talks	This parent never got them; the Kids chapters feed into here.	Age-by-age scripts and timing the parent never had.
Be the safe adult	Most harm comes from known adults; silence endangers kids.	Open door, no blame, POCSO-aware; navigate addiction safely.
Reach every parent	The most stretched have the least time, money and privacy.	Offline, in-language, via pediatricians and ASHA workers.

The same principles, on the nine Chapter 8 games

GAME	THE DEPTH MOVE FROM THESE PERSONAS
Us, After Kids (g61)	The couple and the self after children; intimacy and identity, not just logistics.
Equal Parents (g62)	End "babysitting": Vikram from helping to owning; the default-parent fix.
Looking After You (g63)	Divya first: postpartum mental health, burnout, the parent's erased self.
The Talks (Age by Age) (g64)	The Parent Layer that feeds the Kids chapters; scripts the parent never had.
Break the Cycle (g65)	Suresh: positive discipline without fear or shame; repair; break the silence.
Raising Gender-Diverse Kids (g66)	Priya: affirming is protective; meet fear with facts, not blame.
Raising Neurodiverse Kids (g67)	Meena: difference to support, not a fault to cure; "it's not your fault".
Navigating Addictions (g68)	Kamla: protect the kids, find support, no shame; family addiction handled safely.

Be the Safe Adult (g69)

The loop-closer: open-door, no-blame, known-adult-risk parenting that guides the next child into Chapter 1.

And so it begins again

This is the last chapter and the first. The parent who completes Chapter 8 is the parent who opens Chapter 1 with their own child, holding the phone, a little nervous, ready to be the safe source they never had. Eight chapters, one lifelong loop. That's the whole point of SwipeEd, drawn out across a life and handed, gently, to the next one.

That completes the persona set for all eight chapters. Next, on your nod: a chapter-by-chapter game redesign built directly on these briefs, starting wherever you like.